

Searching for the Dead

With thousands of bodies turning up on its railway tracks, the Haryana GRP sets out to identify the victims in Bihar

They are anonymous like their brutal culprits and were discovered strewn along the railway tracks in Punjab and Haryana. They are the nameless and faceless victims, killed by unseen hands in unknown circumstances, perhaps in an alien land—where ironically they may have gone to earn a livelihood. Instead, they lost their identity and today the only recognisable individuality that they have is a number that is tagged to their photographs, which also bears tell-tale signs of their gory end.

The Government Railway Police (GRP) may well have “disposed off” 2,390 unidentified, unclaimed bodies, but following a realisation that the dead perhaps deserved better, a 29-member team of GRP from Chandigarh is on a 12-day mission. “We went to Bihar to make their voices heard. Perhaps we owe this much to them,” says Randhir Singh, DSP, who is leading the team to Bihar. “The main purpose of our visit to Bihar was to ascertain the identity of the 2,390 unclaimed bodies found near the railway tracks between 2003 and 2007,” he said. The extensive campaign launched to identify the unclaimed bodies has been aptly named Operation Pehchan. And Singh knows that his is an uphill task. “So far only

two photographs have been identified. But we have not lost hope,” he says.

The special police team is in Bihar because they have reasons to believe that the bodies belong to migrant labourers from the state, who visit Punjab and Haryana in large numbers to eke out a livelihood during the harvest season. In fact, the team is so convinced that they have so far decided to visit only Bihar to look for the victims’ trails. The first camp was held at the Patna railway station from March 14 to 16, where they displayed several photographs of the victims. Similar camps were organised at the Bhagalpur railway junction from March 17 to 18, and at the Muzaffarpur station from March 20 to 21.

These camps attracted a large number of people. One of them was Rambalak Manjhi who was able to identify his son among the dead. There are others, who have not been able to identify their missing relatives and left the camp with mixed feelings—of disappointment and relief.

Meanwhile, Railway Superintendent of Police, Patna Ajitabh Kumar, who has been picked up as the nodal officer for Bihar, has also flashed orders, asking state GRP men to extend full cooperation to their Haryana



counterparts in the identification of the bodies. The Bihar GRP has directed all railway police stations to send across the message about the camps so that more and more people could visit them.

Although, the Haryana Police has labelled most of these deaths as “accidents”, Kumar admits that “foul play” cannot be ruled out. “The railway tracks have always been veritable dumping ground for the criminals. Even in Bihar we often find unclaimed bodies along the railway tracks,” he says. Although Bihar police officers are willing to credit the Haryana police’s “noble initiative to track the victim’s family”, a number of them are unwilling to buy their argument that all the 2,390 dead were victims of railway accidents. Besides, a good number of the

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ers to Punjab and Haryana during the crop sowing and harvesting seasons.

With killing someone becoming easy by the day, nothing helps the culprits cover up their tracks more chillingly than official callousness. Once a body is found on the track, it is reported to the nearest station master by the railway patrol parties. It takes at least three hours for the GRP team to retrieve the body. Since most accident sites are not accessible by road, GRP personnel reach the spot through the next train. By that time, the

body is so badly mangled by running trains that vital clues of foul play are lost.

The laxity on GRP’s part in retrieving these bodies is only matched by the perfunctory post-mortem performed not by the doctors but by Class IV employees. “Since such bodies are found in pieces, it’s taken as the most unpleasant formality,” says a government doctor at Ambala. Even if the physical examination of the body shows injuries inflicted before it was hit by a train, the necessary forensic tests are given a go-by to make